

Asking for Google reviews: what the rule says

Google changed one line of its review policy in February 2026, and the change quietly turned a common piece of advice into something it no longer permits. The rule itself is short and easy to hold. This sheet is the rule, and the wording that stays comfortably inside it.

1 THE RULE, IN GOOGLE'S OWN WORDS

“When soliciting reviews, merchants should not require or pressure users to leave ratings or write reviews while on the premises, nor should they request that specific content be included.”

“We do allow merchants to: Solicit or encourage the posting of content that does represent a genuine experience, without offering incentives to do so or attempting to influence the rating or the contents of the review.”

Google, **Prohibited & restricted content**, help article **7400114**, under Fake & misleading content and behavior → Rating manipulation. Published at support.google.com/contributionpolicy/answer/7400114 and repeated word for word in the Google Business Profile help centre. The wording above was read off Google's live page on **1 September 2026**.

2 WHAT THAT MEANS IN PRACTICE

ASKING IS FINE

Asking a customer for a review is expressly permitted, and always has been. Ask in person, by text, by email, on a card, on an invoice. Ask every customer, on every job.

STEERING THE CONTENT IS NOT

What the policy draws a line at is asking for **particular content inside the review** — a person's name, a service, a town, a keyword, a star rating. The review has to be the customer's, in the customer's words.

One sentence carries the whole rule: **ask for the review, never for what goes in it.**

3 THE ASK THAT WORKS

SAY THIS — IN PERSON, BY TEXT, OR ON A CARD

“Would you mind leaving us a Google review? Just tell us about your experience with Top Tier.”

That is the whole ask, and it is deliberately empty — no person, no service, no town. Send the link or the QR code with it; what matters is that no instructions travel alongside it.

4 WHEN A CUSTOMER ASKS “WHAT SHOULD I WRITE?”

This is where the rule is most likely to be tripped, because the customer is asking for help and the instinct is to give it. Hand the question straight back.

SAY THIS

“Whatever you thought — however the job went. It's your review, so it means more in your own words than in mine.”

Helpful, and it leaves the content with the customer. Anything more specific — “mention the roof,” “mention who came out,” “mention Albertville” — is the request the policy describes, however kindly it is meant.

5 WHAT IS FINE, AND IS OFTEN MISUNDERSTOOD

- ✓ **A customer naming somebody, unprompted.** The policy governs what a business asks for, not what a customer chooses to write. A review that says “Guy came out and walked me through the whole thing” breaks nothing, as long as nobody asked for it.
- ✓ **Reviews already posted.** There is nothing retroactive here. Top Tier's profile stands at **5.0 stars across 18 reviews**, and the rule does not reach back to touch any of them.
- ✓ **Asking however suits the job.** In person at the walk-through, by text that evening, by email with the final invoice, or on a leave-behind card. The policy has nothing to say about the channel.
- ✓ **Asking every single customer.** Not merely permitted – it is the safer path. The same section of the policy separately rules out selectively soliciting positive reviews, so asking everyone the same way, every time, is exactly right.
- ✓ **Following up once.** A reminder is a second ask, and an ask is allowed. What the policy rules out alongside content-steering is pressuring somebody to post while they are standing in front of you, and offering anything of value in exchange.

6 THE ONE PIECE OF COMMON ADVICE THAT IS NOW WRONG

For years the standard search-marketing recommendation was to ask customers to work the service and the city into the review – “ask them to mention roof replacement in Albertville.” It was everywhere, and plenty of businesses were told to do it by people who meant well.

Under the wording above, **that request is now the thing the policy names**. The clause is not restricted to naming staff; it is any request that *specific content be included*, and a service or a town is specific content. Worth knowing, because it is the version of this advice most likely to be repeated by an outside marketing vendor who has not read the February update.

7 WHY THE RULE EXISTS

A review is only worth reading if it reflects what actually happened. Once businesses start supplying the words, reviews stop being evidence and start being copy – and the ratings stop telling a homeowner anything useful. The line Google has drawn is a reasonable one: the business may ask, and the customer decides what to say.

For a company sitting at a perfect rating built on genuine work, that is the favourable version of the rule. It protects the value of reviews that were earned rather than engineered.

8 DO NOT CONFUSE THIS WITH THE PERSONAL INFORMATION POLICY

A separate, much older section of the same page covers **personal information**, and it points the other way. It permits a review to carry “an individual's name if they are a public-facing professional conducting business under their name,” and it names **contractors** in its own list of examples.

So a customer writing about the owner by name is not a personal-information problem, and never was. Two different rules, two different subjects: one is about what a business may *ask for*, the other is about what a review may *contain*. Only the first one changed.

9 WHERE THIS CAME FROM

The clause was added to article 7400114 on **16 February 2026**, between 01:25 and 07:01 UTC, confirmed against archived copies of the page captured either side of the change. Google made no announcement, and the business-facing guidance on getting more reviews still does not mention it, which is why so much of the older advice is still in circulation. Google publishes no detail on how the rule is enforced, and any figure quoted online for a filtering threshold has no source behind it.